St. Joseph's Anglo-Chinese School
Form 5 English Language
Paper 2 Writing – DSE 2022 Paper 2 (Part B): Learning from a sample script

Learning from a sample script — how a Level 5** script handles *content* and *organisation* (60-minute lesson)

Part 1: plan the task and the content (15 min) • Part 2: read the sample and see what it does with content and organisation (30 min) • Part 3: comment, score and write (15 min)

PART 1: BEFORE YOU WRITE — READ THE QUESTION AND PLAN THE CONTENT (15 minutes)

1. The question

The School Management is considering a four-day school week. Students would only need to attend school four days a week instead of five, but the length of each day would be increased by one hour.

You are a member of the Parent-Teacher Association (PTA). Write a letter to the President of the PTA stating your opinion either for or against a four-day school week. Give reasons to support your view.

(DSE 2022 English Language Paper 2, Part B, Question 9 — 'Learning English through Debating'. Reproduced from the question paper.)

2. Task analysis

Genre	Formal letter
Target audience	
Purpose of writing	
Style and tone	
Text-type features (opening and closing)	
Word guide	

3. Build your idea bank

Your letter needs to say WHO benefits and HOW. Fill in the table with as many reasons as you can, then keep the three strongest ones.

Who is affected?	Reasons FOR a four-day week	Reasons AGAINST a four-day week
Students		
Teachers and other school staff		
The school (management)		
Parents and family life		

4. Your writing plan

Plan your own letter before you read someone else's. One line each is enough — you will come back to this plan in Part 3.

Greeting	
Opening paragraph	*purpose • your stance • the three points you will cover*
Main body	
Closing paragraph	
Closing	

PART 2: READ THE SAMPLE — WHAT IT DOES WITH CONTENT AND ORGANISATION (30 minutes)

A. The sample script (Level 5),** *transcribed. Crossed-out words are left out and the writer's own corrections are kept, so this is the version the marker read. The original handwritten script is on the screen.*

[1] Dear Mr. Wong,

[2] I am writing to you to express my opinion for the implementation of a four-day school week proposed by the School Management. It is an indisputable fact that almost all primary to secondary educational institutions across Hong Kong have adopted the five school days a week pattern for students for over many generations. Nonetheless, the debate of cutting the fifth school day in the week, merging with the weekends distributing one hour to the other respective school days is gaining momentum, as the one extra valid day would potentially benefit various stakeholders of the school. In my opinion, this novel pattern of school days is conducive to the students, the school and also the parents.

[3] First, students can achieve a holistic personal development with the four-day school week. The issue of learners in the school being only skilled in taking examinations and studying while overlooking the importance of developing an interest in other extra-curricular activities is always what parents are apprehensive towards. Though this is not done by the school or parents deliberately, students often struggle to choose between using the weekends to do what they like or spend time to prepare for the next test. With Hong Kong's education system being immensely exam-oriented, affecting the future of students, many learners are left with no choice but to choose the latter. Because of this, students may lose their valuable opportunities to develop essential social skills, discover their own true interests and create bonds between peers. So, the one extra day pattern can provide students with more time to try out different kinds of indoor and outdoor activities, from sports to creating art works to playing music. Parents can also use the one extra day to apply for classes that teach the interests of their children. Since that day is already marked as vacant, students do not need to go to the classes after a tiring school day and could spend that day concentrating on their beloved activities and talents. In addition, the extra one day in the weekend can give learners more freedom to meet up with their friends and spend time together, such as watch a movie and so much more. This can alleviate their stress from school through socializing and doing sports. Eventually, with the lengthened weekend, students are able to acquire vital social skills while having a better chance to flourish their talents and generate a stronger bond with their peers using

the extra day provided. In a word, the four days school week can help students to achieve all-rounded excellence.

[4] Second, schools can use the extra hours of each school day to lay down plans for students, which can help them achieve academic excellence. Without a doubt, the education system in Hong Kong is fully driven by exams, along with public exams like the DSE which determines the future of each learner. So, schools always splurge a larger sum of money and resources on providing students with remedial classes, tutorial classes and enhancement classes that are hosted by professionals outside the school in order to help learners catch up with their subjects or enhance their exam performance. Therefore, the extra one hour in the school days can let the schools use it as a buffer for students and teachers to either set extra classes in case the class is falling behind, or host a wide variety of enhancement classes to train students for the future examination and develop useful examination skills, building students' confidence and this is very integral to students too. Moreover, the extra one day of the weekend is also one free day for the teachers and other employers of the school. They could also use the extra day to relieve the stress from work by doing what they like and take a breather. In short, the four day school week can shoulder the responsibility of the school from catching up with the progress, help the students who are in dire need and boost their performance, and also give teachers more time to relax.

[5] Third, the extra day can foster relationship between the parents and their child. The usual 5 days school week, with about 8-9 hours of mandatory lesson time each means parents can spend the day working without the need to worry about their children as they are under schools' supervision. However, that also means after exhausting day of work for parents, sometimes parents return home at midnight in which even the dinner is finished by children themselves or their maid. This comes down to both not having sufficient time to spend doing activities together. To add insult to injury, family issues are often stemmed from lack of communication between parents and children, or lack of care towards the sons and daughters. Therefore, the extra day can be a great opportunity for parents to spend time with their beloved child through doing a multitude of activities together, such as going on a hiking together, shopping together, playing games together and many more. By this, parents can live up to the role of guiding their children through difficulties and giving them unconditional love, as well as having the chance to rejuvenate their relationship if it is estranged. So, the four days school week is conducive to the parents of the students, who are also a part and parcel to a school's integrity.

[6] All in all, the four days school week can give students more freedom to achieve their own greatness, give school a convenient window to suit every student's needs, and a silver bullet for the students' parents to build a lovable family. I believe the implication of cutting one school day and adding other school days with one hour is highly possible, and have every stakeholder of the school to reap benefits from it.

[7] Yours sincerely,
Mr. Smith

B. Read for the gist (3 minutes)

1. Who is writing, and to whom?

2. Is the writer FOR or AGAINST the proposal? Write down the sentence that tells you.

3. One sentence each: what does paragraph [3] say students gain? What does paragraph [4] say the school gains? What does paragraph [5] say parents gain?

_____

_____

_____

C. CONTENT — which ideas, and how are they made convincing?

Task 1. Look back at your idea bank in Part 1. Tick every idea that the sample writer also used. Then write down ONE good idea of yours that the writer did NOT use — could you add it?

_____

_____

Task 2. Complete the content map for the three body paragraphs.

Paragraph	**Who benefits**	**The writer's main point (one sentence)**	**What supports the point (tick in the sample: an explanation of WHY it happens / a concrete example or comparison / a factual detail about Hong Kong / a reference to the other side)**
[3]			
[4]			
[5]			

Task 3. Content that scores 7. The writer does four things. Find and copy the evidence for each one from the sample.

What the writer does	**Evidence from the sample (copy the words)**
(a) Answers the whole question: states an opinion AND gives reasons	
(b) Explains the cause, not just the benefit	
(c) Uses concrete, Hong Kong-specific detail	
(d) Shows he knows the other side, then answers it	

Why does (d) — answering the other side — matter to the marker?

_____

_____

D. ORGANISATION — how the sample is built

Task 4. Label every move in the letter. Choose from the move bank and write the move in the last column.

Move bank: *• Greeting (salutation) • Purpose of writing + your stance • 'Road map': the three points the letter will cover • Point 1 — benefit to students • Point 2 — benefit to the school and its teachers • Point 3 — benefit to parents / family life • Summary of the three points + what the writer hopes will happen • Sign-off*

Move	Paragraph	What the writer is doing (choose from the move bank)
1	[1]	
2	[2]	
3	[3]	
4	[4]	
5	[5]	
6	[6] and [7]	

Task 4b. Look at paragraphs [3], [4] and [5]. Each one ends with a sentence that repeats the point of the paragraph (a 'round-off'). Copy the round-off sentence of [4] and explain why an examiner likes it.

_____

_____

Task 5. The topic sentences

Copy the first sentence of paragraphs [3], [4] and [5] into the table, then answer the questions below.

Paragraph	Topic sentence
[3]	
[4]	
[5]	

What do all three topic sentences have in common? *(Think: how does each one begin? Whose benefit does each one promise?)*

_____

_____

Which sentence in the closing paragraph 'mirrors' the three topic sentences? Copy it.

_____

_____

Task 6. Linking words — where they are, and how to improve them

(a) Find every sentence that begins with a linking word and put the linking word into the right box.

Adding more	Sequencing	Contrasting	Cause and effect	Summarising

(b) Our marker's comment on this script was 'mainly sentence-initial linking words'. Rewrite each sentence so that the linking word moves inside the sentence. The first one is done for you.

Sentence with a sentence-initial linker	Your rewrite
Therefore, students will be able to develop their own talents.	*Students will therefore be able to develop their own talents.*
However, parents will find it hard to spend time with their children.	
In addition, teachers can use the free day for professional development.	

(c) One more organisation fault to notice: paragraph [3] is about 250 words long. Where would you split it into two paragraphs, and why?

_____

_____

E. LANGUAGE — words and patterns worth stealing (10 minutes, or homework)

Task 7. Read each word or phrase and study how the writer uses it in the sample sentence. Then do the writing task at the end.

Word / phrase	**What it means**	**The sentence in the sample**
indisputable	cannot be argued against; certain	It is an indisputable fact that almost all primary to secondary educational institutions across Hong Kong have adopted…
gaining momentum	becoming stronger / more widely supported	the debate of cutting the fifth school day in the week … is gaining momentum
stakeholders	the people who are involved and affected	the one extra valid day would potentially benefit various stakeholders of the school
conducive to	helpful to / good for	this novel pattern of school days is conducive to the students, the school and also the parents
alleviate	make (pain or stress) less severe	This can alleviate their stress from school through socializing and doing sports.
integral	very important (to something)	building students' confidence and this is very integral to students too
in dire need	needing help very much	help the students who are in dire need
splurge (on)	spend a lot of money (on)	schools always splurge a larger sum of money and resources on providing students with…
live up to the role of	do what the role expects of you	parents can live up to the role of guiding their children through difficulties
part and parcel of	an essential part of	parents … are also a part and parcel to a school's integrity
a silver bullet	a simple, instant solution to a problem	and a silver bullet for the students' parents to build a lovable family
reap benefits	gain advantages	every stakeholder of the school (can) reap benefits from it

Two patterns from the sample:

Pattern A: *It is an indisputable fact that + statement.* It is an indisputable fact that almost all schools have adopted the five-day school week for generations.

Pattern B: *With + situation + being + description, + someone + is left with no choice but to + verb.* With Hong Kong's education system being immensely exam-oriented, many learners are left with no choice but to choose the latter.

Task 8. Use FOUR items from the table and BOTH patterns to write TWO sentences about the four-day school week.

_____

_____

_____

_____

PART 3: COMMENT, SCORE AND WRITE (15 minutes)

1. Your comments and scores on the sample

Tick the criteria you can prove from the text, and write the evidence in the last column.

Criterion	What to look for	Evidence from the sample	Score
Content:	All task requirements fulfilled / Good arguments / Good elaboration		/ 7
Language:	Accurate grammar / Good variety of vocabulary & structures / Right style and formality		/ 7
Organisation:	Good flow of ideas / Good paragraphing / Coherent opening & closing paragraphs		/ 7

2. The real marks

Three markers marked this script. Their marks:

Criterion	Marker 1	Marker 2	Third marker	Final (out of 7)
Content	7	6	7	7
Language	7	5	6	6
Organisation	6	5	6	6
Total				18.3 / 21 (≈ 87% → Level 5**)

Discussion: Which two criteria carried this script to a 5**? Where do you think marks were lost?

3. Even a 5** script is not perfect

These lines are taken from the sample. Correct each one.

Line from the sample	Your correction
The usual 5 days school week, with about 8-9 hours of mandatory lesson time …	
So, the four days school week is conducive to the parents of the students …	

… students are able to acquire vital social skills while have a better chance to flourish their talents …	
Third, the extra day can foster relationship between the parents and their child.	
I believe the implication … is highly possible, and have every stakeholder of the school to reap benefits from it.	

4. Your turn

Write the opening paragraph of your own letter (4–5 sentences). Use the plan you made in Part 1.

Greeting • I am writing to … (say what you are writing about) • your stance • tell the reader the three points you will cover

Use at least one pattern or word from the 'steal these' table.

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

5. What to take away

Content, Language and Organisation are 7 marks each in Part B. This script used its **ideas** and the **way they were arranged** to reach a 5** — 14 of its 21 marks — even though its grammar slips. Great writers at Level 5** make sure that (1) every requirement in the question is answered, (2) every reason is explained, not just listed, and (3) the reader always knows which point belongs to which paragraph.